

Boxers in Training *Langol, Manipur*

Fist for Fist

Pushpa Devi is a spunky 17-year-old from Wangjing, in Thoubal district of Manipur, who shares a bare room with seven other girls. She stays away from her family and trains 12 hours a day. But she doesn't mind for it is better than the alternative. A life lost in early marriage and the struggle for daily survival. It's something 27-year-old Mangte Chungneijang Mary Kom was determined to avoid. The four-time World Women's champion in 2002, 2005, 2006 and 2008 and mother of extremely naughty two-year-old twin boys has taken it upon herself to see that Indian women get to deliver a knockout punch in the global ring. With no help from either the state Government or the Sports Authority of India (SAI), her two-year-old boxing academy has already seen champions with S. Nengneihat Kom winning the gold in All-India Inter SAI Boxing Championship in 2007. "I wanted to do something for the sport

and for children from remote areas who have talent but no access to any training facility," says Mary Kom, an inspector in the Manipur Police. Her academy doesn't have an impressive building, a boxing ring or even a signboard. But ask anyone in Imphal and they will guide you to an open field in Langol, which is where her future golden gloves practise. All the girls, 15 of them, live in her home while 20 boys, among them Samananda Singh, Sanit Kumar and Ranjan Singh, have been given accommodation nearby.

Sapam Sila Devi, a shy 16-year-old, forgets her inhibitions the minute she dons her boxing gloves. She's here after appearing at a trial in her village, Hiyanglam Awang Leikai, also

in Thoubal. All she'll say is, "I am happy to get free training from a world champion." It's the same for Neiyangchong Gangte, 16, from Bethel of Senapati district, who's grateful for Mary Kom's generosity of spirit. In the thick of competitions herself, Mary Kom can only be in Imphal for four months a year. "But I don't let the academy stop work. There are coaches round the year," she says.

Mary Kom is fighting almost a lone battle. Her family takes care of the food and lodging of the trainees. The CRPF and the Indian Army have donated gym instruments and boxing kits but there is a lot more that needs to be done. A local bank, Unacco, donates Rs 5,000 per month. She admits she could not have been here without the help of husband K. Onkholer Kom, who works for the uplift of rural children in Manipur. With him spurring her on, she knows she has the courage to take on the system. **Fist for fist.**

by Elora Sen

MARY KOM (CENTRE) WITH HER
TRAINEES AT THE ACADEMY

"I want good boxers to get opportunities and do well in the international arena. This will make me proud."

M.C. MARY KOM, Founder, M.C. Mary Kom Boxing Academy

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